



The state shall soon have contemporary sporting facilities even in the remotest areas; enticing and enabling more and more youngsters to take to sports as recreation as well as career.

The government has shown considerable foresight in developing top-end sporting infrastructures. Astro-turfs are being laid at places like Sirsa, Sonapat and Bhiwani while the one at Shahabad is already sending hockey man and women players to the national team in droves. The Sports Complex at Panchkula can match up to the best in the category anywhere. A sprawling sports complex in an area over 90 acres is coming up at Rohtak; the hometown of the incumbent Chief Minister. 'When it comes to sporting excellence' says Mr. Hooda, 'We shall stop at nothing.'

The state has a pyramid-shaped athlete development program with nurseries for young talents and wings & academies for the career sportpersons. With 'Catch'em Young' mantra in mind, children as young as 8 years, selected through a battery of rigorous physical tests, are getting coaching, free boarding, sporting gears and a monthly emolument of Rs. 3,000. There are 36 such nurseries all over the state

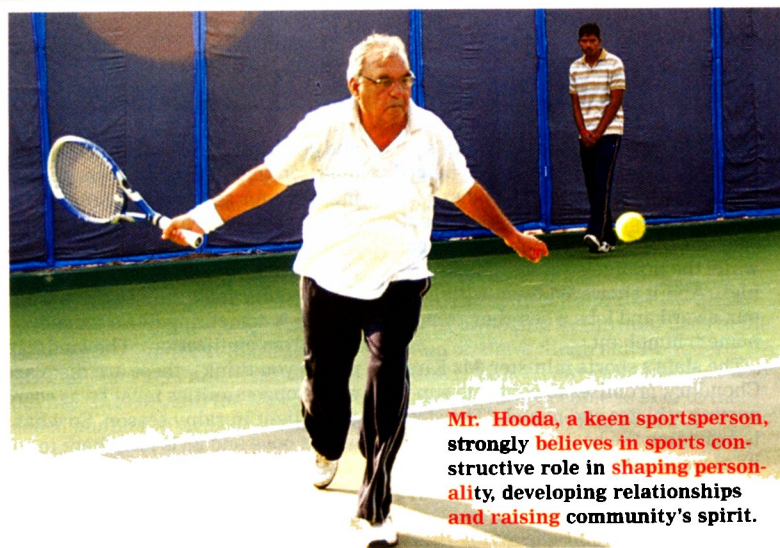
three per cent of the jobs in the police department for the outstanding sportspersons. The Haryana Chief Minister, Mr Bhupinder Singh, elated at the performance of Vijender Singh at the Beijing Olympics, ordered his appointment as Deputy Superintendent of Police. Others to benefit similarly are boxers Akhil Kumar and Jitender, hockey players Mamta Kharab, Sardara Singh and Sandep Singh and cricketer Joginder Singh. The government also doubled the award money for the players winning gold, silver and bronze medals in Olympic Games to Rs two crore, Rs. one crore and Rs. fifty lakh respectively.

Mr. Hooda followed it up with announcing setting up of top class boxing, wrestling, football kabaddi and basketball academies. Virender Sehwag, the Nawab of Najafgarh was allotted a huge chunk of prime land at Jhajjar to set up cricket, football and swimming academies.

A regional centre of Sports Authority of India (SAI) has come up at Sonapat with international standard playing facilities. It has set up a special sports training centre in athletics, boxing, and judo and table tennis at HAU, Hisar. The state has also been among the enthusiastic implementer of central government's sports promotion scheme Panchayat Yuva Khel Krida Aviyan (PYKKA).

The government has put a battery of incentive schemes in place to motivate athletes to go for the kill. As many as six players are given Bhim Awards every year. Assured cash awards are there for medal winners in various sporting events. College and school students too have dedicated scholarships schemes. An innovative scheme UK-3 [Utkrisht Khiladi Kalyan Kosh] has been set up to take care of sportsperson in distress. A pension scheme has been announced for Arjuna, Bhim and Dhyanchand awardees of the state. PV Rathie President, Haryana Olympic Association says, 'Our eyes are on grassroots, we are all keyed up to complement government sports promotion schemes'.

'The government has more in mind,' says Dharamvir, Chief Secretary of the state, 'A new sports policy will soon be unveiled that would put the government's engagement on this count to next level'. The policy, the sources say, is next generation and would add momentum to the efforts of a state that is already sprinting on the highway of sporting excellence. ■



**Mr. Hooda, a keen sportsperson, strongly believes in sports constructive role in shaping personality, developing relationships and raising community's spirit.**

### Awards agalore

In a bid to reach out to talents in rural areas, the government has embarked on an ambitious project of constructing 171 block-level sports stadiums, named as Shri Rajiv Gandhi Khel Parisar. Work is on at a break-neck speed and as many as 95 of them ready

where over 600 young athletes are being groomed in games as diverse as athletics, basketball, cricket, gymnastics, wrestling, boxing, badminton, kabaddi, hockey, judo, football, table tennis and volleyball.

In a bid to address career concerns, the Haryana Government has reserved